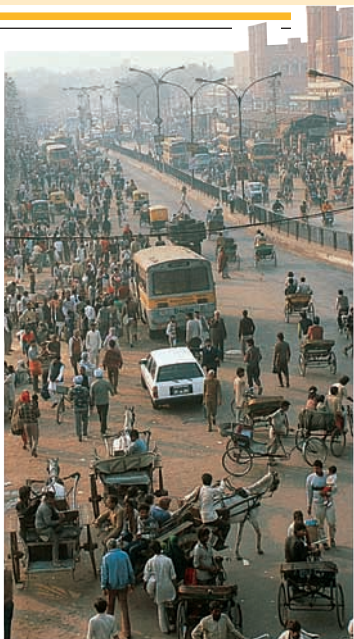




GROWING CITIES

A large proportion of Asia's population still lives in the countryside as farmers, but the number living in cities is rising steeply. The largest cities in Asia now have populations of more than 10 million. These megacities, along with many other cities in the continent, are destined to grow even faster as people move from the countryside to towns.

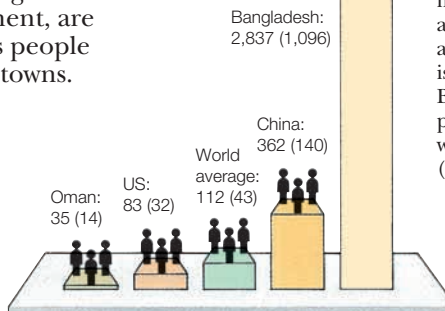
This crowded street scene is in India's capital, New Delhi. India is one of the world's most densely populated countries.

LARGEST CITIES IN ASIA

Tokyo, Japan	34,200,000
Seoul, South Korea	22,300,000
Mumbai, India	19,470,000
Jakarta, Indonesia	17,590,000
Osaka, Japan	17,510,000

Population density

The figures on the chart show the number of people per sq mile (per sq km). Countries outside Asia are included as a comparison.



POPULATION DENSITY

Large areas of the Middle East and central Asia are empty wilderness, unsettled by people because of their extreme dryness or cold temperatures. Most of the population is concentrated in the fertile river valleys and coastal lowlands of south and east Asia. Aside from the island city-state of Singapore, Bangladesh is the most densely populated country in Asia with 2,837 people per sq mile (1,096 per sq km).

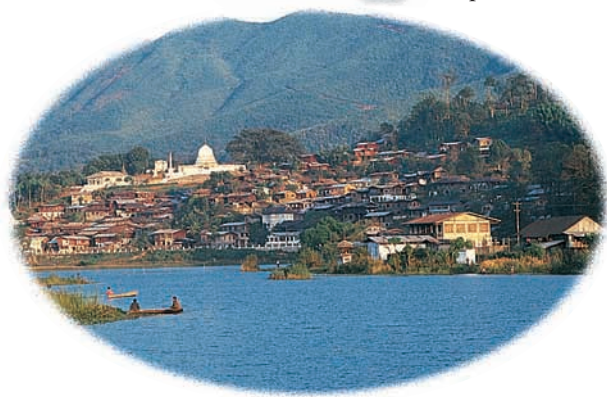
A Bedouin man in Jordan may have more than one wife and many children.



POPULATION GROWTH

Three out of every five people in the world live in Asia. Seven of the world's 10 most populated countries are located here, with China and India heading the list. Between them these two countries account for about 40 percent of the world's population. In mainland China a strictly enforced government policy to restrict family size to just one child has slowed the rate of population growth, but elsewhere in the continent it is still very high. In 2000, India's population rose to over 1 billion and Indonesia's passed over 210 million.

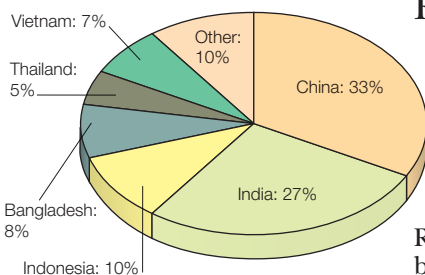
In China, a family with just one child receives free education and a housing allowance.



RIVER VALLEYS

The first peoples settled in fertile river valleys where they could grow crops. They built irrigation systems to channel water from rivers to the crops. Today, rivers are still important to the people of southern and eastern Asia. In addition to irrigation, rivers are used for fishing and for drinking, and are dammed to produce hydroelectric power. Rivers often provide a country's main means of transportation, and some are the focus around which countries have developed.

World's top rice-growing countries (2003)



RICE

Half the world's population depends on rice as a principal source of food, so a rice shortage can cause terrible famine. This plant, native to Southeast Asia, has been cultivated in the region for at least 7,000 years. In recent decades, new varieties of rice have been developed to help feed Asia's growing population. These new strains of rice are part of the "Green Revolution," which applies scientific knowledge to plant breeding and uses technology to increase productivity.